

Greece



The Balkan state of Greece is bounded on three sides by the Mediterranean, Aegean, and Ionian seas. It has a strong seafaring tradition, with some of the world's richest shipowners.

**GEOGRAPHY**

Mountainous peninsula and over 2000 islands. Large plain along the mainland's Aegean coast.

**CLIMATE**

Mainly Mediterranean, with dry, hot summers. Alpine climate in northern mountain areas.

**PEOPLE & SOCIETY**

Postwar industrial development altered the dominance of agriculture and seafaring. The rural exodus to industrial cities has been stemmed but a third of the population now lives in Athens. Age-old culture and Greek Orthodox Church balance social mobility. Civil marriage and divorce became legal only in 1982.



INSIGHT: *The modern Olympics, first held in Athens in 1896, evolved from Olympia's ancient Greek games*

**THE ECONOMY**

One of Europe's leading tourist destinations. World's largest shipping fleet. Fruit, vegetables, olives. Large black economy. Public debt and budget deficit remain high.

**FACTFILE**

OFFICIAL NAME: Hellenic Republic

DATE OF FORMATION: 1829

CAPITAL: Athens

POPULATION: 11.2 million

TOTAL AREA: 50,942 sq. miles
(131,940 sq. km)

DENSITY: 221 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Greek*, Turkish, Macedonian, Albanian

RELIGIONS: Orthodox Christian 98%, Muslim 1%, other 1%

ETHNIC MIX: Greek 98%, other 2%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Euro = 100 cents